

Oak

An oak is more than just a tree—it is home to as many as 350 species of insect and many other animals. Oaks and other deciduous trees change with the seasons. The oak's seeds are found in fruits called acorns. A single oak tree can produce 90,000 acorns a year.



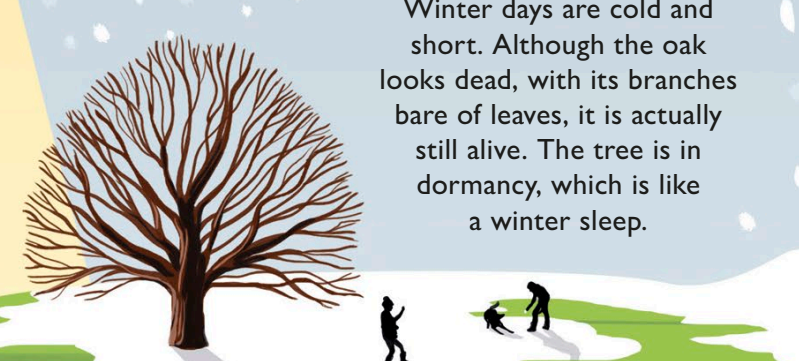
When ripe, acorns break off their stalks and fall to the ground. Each acorn contains a seed that can grow into a new tree.

Fall



Fall winds blow the acorns off the tree. As the days get cooler and shorter, the tree prepares for winter. Its green leaves turn to shades of yellow, orange, and red, before dropping to the ground.

Winter



Winter days are cold and short. Although the oak looks dead, with its branches bare of leaves, it is actually still alive. The tree is in dormancy, which is like a winter sleep.



Fungus Eventually, an old oak will be invaded by fungi, which cause it to decay. The weakened trunk may then break under the weight of the branches above or by the force of the wind.



Deciduous Like the oak, this cherry tree is deciduous—it sheds its leaves each fall and grows new leaves in spring, along with pink blossoms. Trees that keep their leaves all year round, such as pine trees, are called evergreens.